



Jargon Buster

Access Time: The total time a device requires to find and retrieve a piece of information.

Absolute Time In Pre-groove (ATIP): Address and recording information encoded in the wobble groove on CD-R and CD-RW media. Based on this information, a burner can determine the absolute position in Pregroove.

Buffer Under Run (BURN)-Proof: For a CD-RW drive to support the BURN-Proof feature, it must make use of a special LSI (Large Scale Integration) chipset. These chips contain proprietary microcode developed by Sanyo. In order for BURN-Proof to work, the CDR Software used for recording must also be BURN-Proof compatible.

Eight bit to Fourteen bit Modulation code (EFM): EFM is the modulation code used in all CD recording. This low-level and very critical channel coding technique maximizes pit sizes on the disc by reducing frequent transitions from 0 to 1, or 1 to 0.

Error Correction Code (ECC): A system of scrambling and recording redundant data onto the disc as it is recorded. During playback, this redundant information helps to detect and correct errors that may arise during data transmission.

Firmware: Firmware is the programming instructions contained on a ROM chip within the CD recorder, which tells the recorder how to respond to commands issued by software. Some firmware is flash-upgradeable—you can upgrade the firmware by running a piece of software. Other firmware is coded into a non-rewriteable chip, so the entire chip must be changed in order to upgrade firmware.

ISO 9660 Format: The most common international standard for the logical format for files and directories on a CD-ROM. Some other common logical formats such as Joliet and Rock Ridge are extensions of ISO 9660.

Joliet: Joliet is an extension of the ISO 9660 standard developed by Microsoft to allow CDs to be recorded using long filenames, and using the Unicode international character set. Joliet allows you to use filenames up to 64 characters in length, including spaces.

Lead-In: An area at the beginning of each session on a recordable compact disc which is left blank for the session's Table of Contents (ToC). The lead-in is written when a session is closed, and takes up 4,500 sectors on disc (1 minute, or roughly 9 MB).

Lead-out: An area at the end of a session which indicates the end of the data. The first lead-out on a disc is 6750 sectors (1.5 minutes, about 13 MB) long. Any subsequent lead-outs are 2250 sectors (.5 minute, about 4 MB). Writing the lead-out closes the session.

Mount Rainier: This is a standard for high speed CD-RW drives that enables native OS support for data storage on a CD-RW disc. It makes data storage easier by including features such as defect management, drive 2K addressing, background formatting and standardisation of both the command set and physical layout of the drives.

One of the biggest advantages of having a Mount Rainier supported drive is that you don't need to wait for the drive to format a CD-RW before putting some data onto it. This is the background formatting feature at work.

where we got extreme highs and lows of data transfer. Liteon and Sony were neck-to-neck in competition with 20.3 MBps and 20.2 MBps respectively, while the other three drives languished below the 1 MBps mark. The Samsung drive took the crown in the disc recognition tests with a time of 3.16 seconds; BenQ came in last with 9.07 seconds. Sony won the transfer rate tests, with a speed of 6.2X; Samsung came in last with 2.79X—the increase in buffer size did not seem to help much.

In the SiSoft Sandra tests, it was the

Samsung which shone in the sequential read tests with a transfer rate of 8 MBps, while the BenQ surprised us with a good 7 MBps, leaving the other three drives eating its dust. The same trend was repeated in the random read tests. The access time scores were a completely different story with the Liteon and Sony drives finishing last. Samsung again took the top honours with 205 seconds followed by LG with 297 seconds.

In the VOB file extraction test, the Samsung 52X finished the extraction in just 41 seconds, 11 seconds earlier than

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